



solidarity movement led the way throughout Eastern Europe for the rapid, yet peaceful decline of communism in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Poland enjoys fertile farmland, and even though the country

has recently transformed itself into a capitalist democracy, nearly a third of its citizens maintain a rural lifestyle, living and working on small, family-run farms.

FARM LIFE

Unlike in other communist countries, Polish farms were never taken over by the state but remained the property of their owners. As a result, Poland is home to almost two million farms. Most are small, family-run affairs which exist in order to feed those who work on them, and not to produce food for sale.

Small-scale Polish farmers seldom use machinery, and instead rely on human and animal power.



COLORFUL COSTUMES

About 60 distinct ethnic regions exist in Poland. In some highland areas, traditional dress is still made and worn on holidays and at festivals. In other areas, folk costumes are made mostly for dance groups or choirs.



FOLK ART

For centuries, traditional art has thrived in rural Poland. The paintings on the walls of this cottage are a good example of folk art—the creation and decoration of functional objects.

